

Case Study: Phishing Attack on College Students

Phishing is a type of cybercrime where attackers trick individuals into revealing sensitive information such as passwords, bank details, or OTPs by pretending to be a trusted entity. A common example involves emails or messages that appear to come from official sources like banks, universities, or popular websites.

In a typical phishing attack, the attacker first creates a fake email or website that closely resembles a legitimate one. Next, they send messages to users, often creating urgency—for example, claiming that an account will be suspended unless immediate action is taken. The victim clicks on the provided link, which redirects them to a fake login page. Once the user enters their credentials, the attacker captures the information and uses it for unauthorized access or financial fraud.

College students are frequent targets because they actively use emails, online payment apps, and social media, but may not always verify sources carefully. In one realistic scenario, a student receives an email claiming to be from their university portal asking them to “update credentials.” Trusting the email, they enter their login details and later find their account compromised.

The consequences of phishing include financial loss, identity theft, data breaches, and emotional stress. It highlights the importance of verifying sources, avoiding suspicious links, and maintaining strong cybersecurity practices.